Updated: Oct 2026

UMER SOHAIL

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. Economics, University of Delaware, Newark, DE — Exp. Jan 2027
Fields: International Trade, Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics

M.S. Economics and Applied Econometrics, University of Delaware, Newark, DE — May 2024

B.Sc. (Honors) Economics, Minor in Mathematics, LUMS, Lahore, Pakistan — May 2021

JOB MARKET PAPER

Trade Liberalization and Firm Adjustment: Evidence from Pakistan
with Zehra Farooq (FBR, Pakistan) — Draft, October 2026

We study how firms adjust to preferential access to a large export market. Between November 2012 and January 2014, the European Union removed most of its remaining tariffs on Pakistani products in two steps—flood-relief preferences on a narrow set of products, followed by GSP+—without requiring tariff cuts in return. Using corporate tax records for 3,810 firms and variation across products in tariffs before the cuts, we find that each percentage point of tariff exposure raised firm export value by about 19 percent, mainly after the second, broader step, and Pakistan's exports shifted toward the EU. Export growth came with lower recorded production wage bills, while the evidence on capital is inconclusive. Export estimates are larger for more productive firms, and less productive firms became less likely to report positive sales or wages; among large firms, exporters expanded exports and cut production wage bills, while some non-exporters increased their recorded capital stock.

WORKING PAPERS

Causal Impact of Barter Trade Policy during a Foreign Exchange Reserves Crisis
with Fraz Ahmed (Carnegie Mellon University) — Draft, December 2025

When Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves collapsed in 2023, the government introduced a barter mechanism allowing goods-for-goods trade with Afghanistan, bypassing frozen banking channels. Using transaction-level customs data and product-level variation in barter eligibility, we show barter-eligible products experienced 30% higher export quantities during the crisis peak. Effects emerged during reserve depletion and dissipated as payment systems resumed, demonstrating that temporary interventions can sustain trade during payment system failures without persistent distortions.

Towards Win-Win: Evidence from Commercial Dispute Resolution in India
with Manaswini Rao, Sandhya Seetharaman, and Raghav Pandey — Draft, October 2024

We leverage the random assignment of commercial cases to judges in newly established commercial courts in India to examine the impact of judge-mediated settlement on firm outcomes. We estimate large positive effects on plaintiff profitability, primarily among financial sector firms, and negative effects among defendants driven by the timing of litigation rather than settlement itself. Suggestive evidence that settlement mitigates losses indicates potential Pareto improvements from expedited dispute resolution.

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Instructor of Record, University of Delaware, Newark, DE
- Principles of Macroeconomics (26 students, online/asynchronous) — Summer 2026
- Economic Issues and Policies (45 students, online/asynchronous) — Winter 2026

Teaching Assistant — Graduate Level, University of Delaware, Newark, DE
- Development Economics — Spring 2025
- Econometric Theory — Spring 2024
- Microeconomic Theory I — Fall 2023

Teaching Assistant — Undergraduate Level, University of Delaware, Newark, DE
- Development Economics — Spring 2025
- Banking and Monetary Policy — Fall 2024

Teaching Assistant, Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS), Lahore, Pakistan
- Mathematical Applications in Economics — Spring 2021
- Macroeconomics — Fall 2021
- Econometrics — Spring 2020
- Intermediate Microeconomics — Fall 2020

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, University of Delaware (Prof. Manaswini Rao) — June 2024 – Present
Applied judge IV strategy to estimate causal effects of judicial decisions on firm outcomes; built reproducible pipelines merging court records with firm financial data in Stata and R.

Research Assistant, University of Delaware (Prof. Nisha Chikhale) — June – August 2025
Constructed longitudinal PSID panel for causal policy analysis; built full replication files.

Research Assistant, University of Manchester, Manchester, UK — July – August 2021
Extracted and cleaned administrative tax records for quasi-experimental policy research.

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

AI Automation Consultant, TeamLift — September 2025 – July 2026
Design and deploy AI workflow automations and agent-based systems for client organizations; translate large language model tools into measurable efficiency gains across diverse teams.

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

- Sally Latham Graduate Research Award, University of Delaware — 2026
- Dean's Honour List, LUMS — 2018 – 2021
- Graduated with Distinction, LUMS — 2021

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, Python, SQL, LaTeX, Git, Claude Code, Codex, Excel

Methods: Causal Inference, Quasi-Experimental Design, Instrumental Variables, Difference-in-Differences

REFERENCES

Adrienne Lucas (Chair)	**Parag Mahajan**	**Manaswini Rao**	**Shafaat Yar Khan**
Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics
University of Delaware	University of Delaware	University of Delaware	Syracuse University
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